

Communication

Basic Concept of Communication

- Communication is the process of sharing information to achieve a common understanding between others and us.
- It is the act of transmitting information, thoughts, opinions, or feelings, through speech, signs, or actions, from a source to a receiver.
- Communication is essential for effective social interaction between people.

Communication...Cont'd

As a communicator, a manager needs to be aware of six basic aspects of communication.

- 1) The **purpose** to be achieved by the message
- 2) The **person** (s) to whom the **message is directed**
- 3) The **sender** of the message
- 4) The **content of the message**, i.e. the message to be conveyed
- 5) The alternative **channels** for communicating the message.
- 6) The need for **feedback** or a response to the message

The communication process

- The Communication process involves the following important stages and elements:

1. The Source: Encoding the Message

- a) Source is person who initiates communication with the need to transmit an idea.
- b) **Encoding** is the process of **changing idea into message** using words or nonverbal signs.

The communication... process ...Cont'd

2. **The Message**: conveying Meaning

- a) Message is the result of the encoding process, what the sender wants to communicate to the receiver.
- b) **Channel** is the carrier of the message; i.e. the means by which the message travels (e.g. telephone, memo, face to face etc.)

The communication... process ...Cont'd

3.The Recipient: Decoding the Message

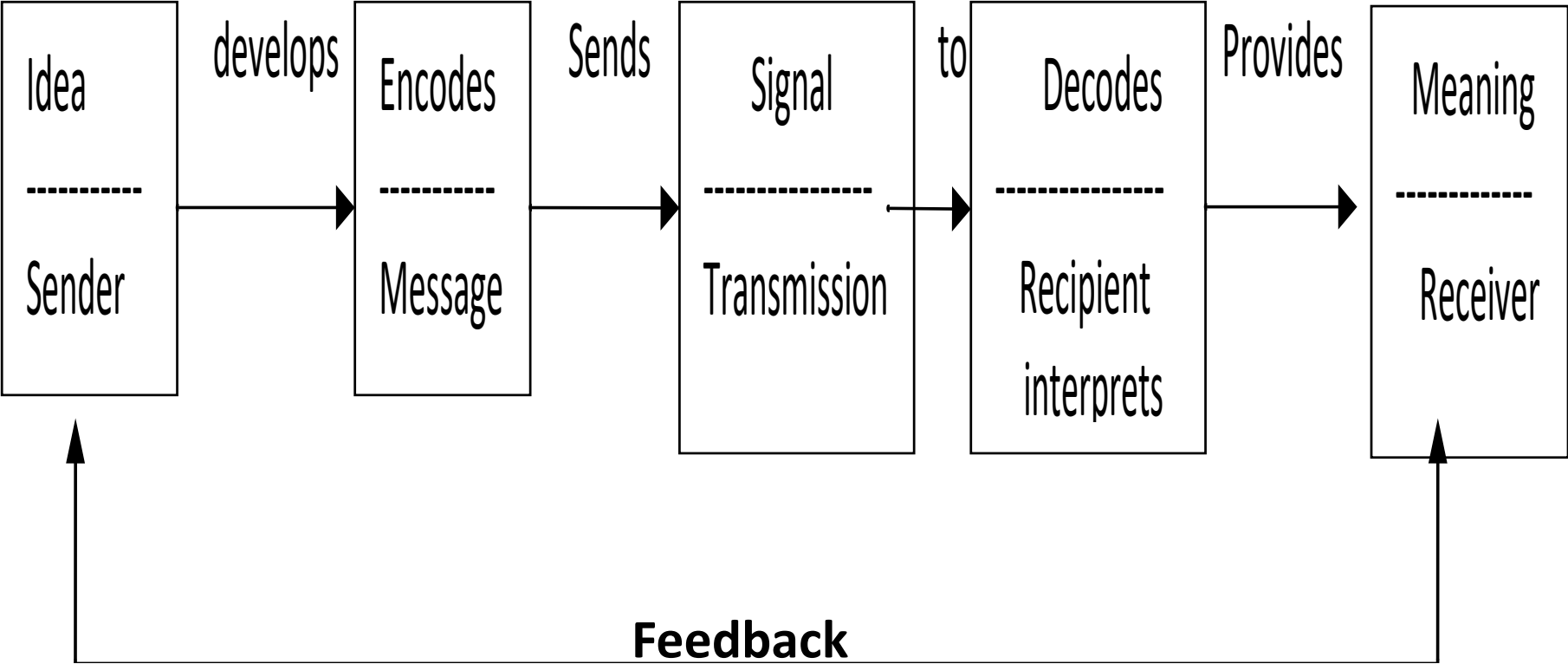
- a) **Recipient** is the receiver of the message. Recipients receive messages selectively.
- b) **Decoding** is the process of changing the message into a form of idea. Involves interpretation, i.e. the receiver translates the message in light of his/her previous experiences and frame of reference.

The communication... process ...Cont'd

4. **Feedback** is the information, which the sender gets from the recipient after a message has been sent, and from which the sender can determine the success of communication.

5. **Noise** consists of factors, which can **distort or obscure the intended message**. It can occur at any point in communication.

Model of the communication process



Channels of Communication

- **Communication networks define the channels (media) by which information flows.**
- **Messages are sent through either formal or informal channels of communication.**

Formal Communication

Formal communication flows in three directions. The formal networks (channels) are typically:

1. Vertical,
 2. Follow the authority chain, and
 3. Limited to task-related communications.
- They are intentionally designed by the formal organization.

Formal Communication...Cont'd

When developing and using the formal channel, it must:

- be known to everyone,
- link every member with the organizational structure,
- be as direct as possible, and
- be clear that the message is authenticated.

Formal Communication...Cont'd

- Formal communication is basically classified between verbal and non-verbal communications.

i) Verbal Communication

- The verbal process is a system of sounds which can be arranged to represent objects, ideas and emotions. The two most commonly used verbal communications are oral and written.

A) Oral communication skills

- The human voice, or speech is not only the most commonly used but it is also quick and direct.

a)Advantages of Oral Communication

- It has a greater variety of applications than written communication
- It is a natural and human medium
- It is usually faster and more economical
- It allows immediate feedback (quick response)
- It is more personal and can appear less formal and authoritarian

Advantages of Oral Communication...Cont'd

- It allows for questions and hence uncertainties can be eliminated
- Nonverbal language, in the form of facial expressions and physical posture can be “read”
- It is easier to be convincing in conversation, because there is the opportunity to use personal charisma
- Use of the spoken word can engender an atmosphere of good will
- It gives a feeling of importance (recognition)

a)Types of oral messages

Oral messages are of two types:

1. Meetings (face to face) and
2. Telephone conversations (ear-to-ear).

i) ***Meetings*** – A meeting involves a discussion among two or more people. It allows exchange of ideas, generation of new ideas, reeducation of semantic difficulties and increased commitment.

Types of oral messages...Cont'd

ii) *Telephone Conversations*

- The voice should be clear, distinct, evenly placed, pleasant, and natural.
- The rules for telephone conduct include, being courteous, avoiding slang, being brief, speaking clearly, not eating or drinking while talking, picturing the person sympathetically and refraining from interrupting the person.

- It is a widely used communication in an organization.
- Orders, instructions, progress reports, return, notices, memos, etc. are communicated in writing.

(a) Principles of written communication

- Choose words precisely
- Use short rather than long words
- Use concrete rather than abstract words
- Economize on words
- Avoid overused or hackneyed phrases and jargon
- Use positive words that convey courtesy
- Prefer the active to the passive voice

Written communication...Cont'd

b)Advantages

- Both sender and receiver have record of the message
- It encourages clear thinking

c)Disadvantages

- It is likely to be misunderstood
- It consumes time and money
- It has slow feedback

Active Listening as a Communication Skill

- Communication is dependent not only on the ability to send a message, but also on the ability to receive it.
- One is not born with the ability to listen effectively; it is a skill, which has to be developed.

Principal rules for active listening

- a. Empathetic responses**
- b. Restatement**
- c. Paraphrasing**
- d. Questioning techniques**
- e. Summative statements**
- f. Making eye contact**

Principal rules for active listening...Cont'd

g) Avoid distracting actions or gestures

h) Avoid interrupting the speaker

i) Don't over talk

j) Suspend judgment and avoid making decisions until the speaker has finished

k) Exhibit affirmative head nods and appropriate facial expressions

- Effective teaching and communication are synonymous
- Barriers to class-room communication include
 - inaudibility of speech
 - abnormal speed of speech
 - unfamiliar pronunciation
 - use of unfamiliar words (terms)

Barriers to verbal classroom...Cont'd

- lack of understanding of the basic knowledge of the student (known as referent confusion)
- day dreams on the part of the student
- on systematic presentation of the subject matter
- lack of scope of immediate feedback
- lack of physical facilities in the classroom
- failure to apply active teaching and learning methods.

ii)Nonverbal Communication Skills

- Nonverbal communication includes all messages that are not encoded in words.
- A message depends more on nonverbal than on verbal communication.

Different forms of nonverbal communication

- Body placement
- Posture
- Gestures
- Facial expression
- Vocal tone
- Eye contact
- Silence
- Time
- Distance
- Clothing, dress and appearance

Informal Communication

- The informal network or grapevine is free to move in any direction, skip authority levels, and is likely to satisfy group members' social needs as it is to facilitate task accomplishments.
- It occurs when members of the organization communicate directly and personally with one another-vertically and horizontally without following formal channel.

Informal Communication

- The grapevine has three characteristics:
 1. It is not controlled by management ,
 2. It is perceived by most employees as being more believable and reliable than formal communications issued by top management, and
 3. It is largely used to serve the self interests of those people within it.

Directions of Communication

- Communication can flow vertically or laterally/horizontally. The vertical dimension can be further divided into downward and upward directions.

(A)Downward communication

- It is a communication that moves from the top level management to the lower hierarchy of the organization. It follows the line of authority.

Downward communication...Cont'd

- There are about five types of communications from superior to subordinate. These include:
 - i) instructions about specific task (job)
 - ii) rational about why task needs to be done and how it relates to other tasks (on attention seeking problems)
 - iii) information about organizational policies & procedures
 - iv) feedback about the performance levels of individual
 - v) information regarding the organization's goals.

Channels (methods) of DC

- The chain of authority, letters, loudspeaker system, unions, video-recording, telephone, newsletters, lunches with management, etc.
- The loss of information, lack of clarity, credibility, order of presentation and wrong timing are among the limitations of downward communications.

B) Upward communication

- It is a flow of information from the lower level to the higher level of the organization.
- It is one means by which subordinates are made accountable to superiors.
- It is used to provide feedback to higher-ups, inform them to progress forward, and relay current problems.
- It keeps managers aware of how employees feel about their jobs, coworkers and the organization in general.

Upward communication...Cont'd

Examples are:

- Performance reports, suggestion boxes, employee attitude surveys, grievance procedures, special meetings, informal “gripe” sessions, resignation interviews, resource requests, evaluative information, explanations on the academic or disciplinary treatment of specific students and curricular program documents.

(C)Horizontal (Lateral) Communication

- Horizontal communication takes place among members of the same work group, among members of work groups at the same level, among managers at the same level, or among any horizontally equivalent personnel.
- It can be either formal or informal and is found to be the strongest & most easily understood.

Horizontal (Lateral) Communication...Cont'd

- Its major propose are: coordinating tasks, solving problems, sharing information with colleagues, resolving conflicts, achieving and promoting team work.
- It is less subject to distortion because of a common sense of reference & a reduced sense of threat.

Improving Communication

Suggestions to improve communication of a manager are:

- **Communicate:** People need information
- **Know your objective**
- **Know the receiver**
- **Formulate your message**
- **Be complete**
- **Be clear and brief**
- **Consider how the message is best communicated**
- **Watch your timing**

Improving Communication ...Cont'd

- **Be aware of :** your attitude, behavior, non-verbal communication, gestures and facial expressions .
- **Keep in mind that:** Positive feelings and emotions inspire positive attitudes amongst the staff and learners.
- **Encourage up ward communication**
- **Listen effectively**
- **Make use of effective feedback:**
- **Use the grapevine**

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